Regardless of having been ‘called on the carpet’, Erich Mielke continued to plough resources into infiltrating foreign organisations ‘bent upon attacking the GDR from within’. He talked about the need to discover enemy plans in order to blunt any such attacks by using spies, subversion and industrial espionage. Writing in ‘Einheit’, a journal dedicated to socialist theory, Mielke claimed such activity was necessary to preserve the unity of the socialist society.11 The article caught the eye of the US Ambassador to East Berlin, John Sherman Cooper, who sent a revealing cable to Washington:

**The state security organisation remains an enigma wrapped up in a mystery in that the members of the Organisation are not listed publicly nor is any budget for the ministry published along with the government’s budget. Members of the state security organisation carry military rank as members of the Police forces inside East Germany. The organisation is controlled and run by the central committee of the SED and, in the last analysis, by the twenty-three members of the Politburo.**

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In stark contrast to the hugely funded MfS, West German intelligence efforts to monitor the East German leadership were clumsy, given the difficult operating environment. In fact, they did not have a single source within the MfS, the SED Politburo, the government, or anywhere else. Over a period of four decades, not one of the at least 15,000 spies from the BND, Military Counterintelligence Service, or the Federal Office for the Protection of the Constitution, ventured into the GDR, which was only snooped on from a distance and not up close, meaning intelligence was sketchy at best. Instead, agents used various sources, including Neues Deutschland, to gather morsels about Honecker’s schedule. Based on the gaps, conclusions were drawn about his vacation, sick days or private